3.2 A Diverse Society

What would you look for if you were searching for a new homeland? You might look for a place that was prosperous and productive and tolerant of differences. For many immigrants, the Middle Colonies seemed like such a place.

MAIN IDEA In addition to being economically successful, the Middle Colonies were culturally diverse.

GROWTH OF CITIES

A stream of settlers, hungry for new opportunities, moved to cities along the Atlantic coast, especially the ports of New York City and Philadelphia. As the colonies produced more and more goods, trade from these ports also grew, and people could find a variety of work in the cities.

Founded in 1681, Philadelphia was the fastest-growing city in the colonies. It started out as a village on the Delaware River and grew to more than 2,000 people in 1700. By 1760, the population had rocketed to roughly 23,000 people, outstripping New York and Boston. The city thrived on crops and trade. Philadelphia's merchants forged relationships with farmers who needed to sell their wheat, livestock, and lumber and with dealers who wanted to market these **commodities**, or goods, in the West Indies and elsewhere.

Philadelphia was an attractive city. Pennsylvania's founder, William Penn, drew up plans for Philadelphia while establishing his own colony. He conceived the city as a large "green country town," with wide streets in a grid pattern, public parks, ample lots, and brick houses.

One of Philadelphia's most famous brick buildings is Independence Hall, which was called the Pennsylvania State House when it was first established in 1753.

Meanwhile, New York City was also expanding. The English acquired the city in 1664 as part of their takeover of the Dutch colony New Netherland. The brick houses with low-sloping tile roofs that lined the city's cobblestoned streets looked exactly like those in Dutch towns. As the city expanded, the English made their mark by building houses of brick and wood in their own style.

After the English took over the city, New York merchants maintained ties with the Netherlands and its colony, the Dutch West Indies. They continued to ship grain, flour, dried fish, timber, and other goods to Amsterdam. Because of these ties, New York City's population more than doubled between 1720 and 1760.



American Products
Cities in the colonies wouldn't have grown without the work of artisans like Cornelius Kierstede of New York. He made this silver teapot around 1720. He shaped the spout into the form of a bird and engraved the purchaser's initials into the side.

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AMERICAN PLACES

Philadelphia Rowhouses

The houses of Society Hill date to around 1690. Rowhouses like these helped support the growing number of people living near the busy docks where goods were traded.

VARIETY OF IMMIGRANTS

When the English took possession of New Netherland, it was already home to the Dutch, Swedes, Finns, Norwegians, French Protestants, Jews, and other settlers. This **diversity**, or wide variety of people, was partly due to the Dutch, who had opened immigration to many different groups. It made the population of the Middle Colonies unique among the regions of America.

After the English takeover, most new immigrants came from England and Germany. German artisans created the Pennsylvania long rifle for hunting. They also designed the **Conestoga wagon**, which was capable of carrying up to four tons of cargo. Other German artisans were ironworkers and makers of glass, furniture, and kitchenware.

The farmland and cities drew immigrants to the Middle Colonies. But immigrants also came to enjoy something that was much less concrete but, perhaps, even more important: religious freedom.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What ideas or events caused the populations of Philadelphia and New York City to change over time?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What caused the population of the Middle Colonies to differ from that of New England and the Southern Colonies?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How did German immigrants contribute to the success of the Middle Colonies?

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